

Email Migration Plan

Moving White Box Studio email from BOX / cPanel to Google Workspace

ADDRESSES MOVING

info@white-box.co.il
daphna@white-box.co.il

HANDS-ON TIME

About 2 hours
spread over 2–3 weeks

RISK

Low, if you follow
the order of steps

DONE — cutover completed 7 September 2026. Mail for `white-box.co.il` now arrives in Google Workspace. Steps 1–7 were carried out and verified that afternoon; external mail was confirmed landing in Gmail the same day. Final DNS: **MX** `smtp.google.com` **priority 1**, and exactly one SPF record, `v=spf1 include:_spf.google.com ip4:148.251.82.238 ~all`.

Still to do: Step 8 (re-run the mail import to sweep up anything that reached BOX between the first import and the switch), Step 9 (DKIM and DMARC — the domain has never had either), and Step 10 (**do not cancel BOX before about 21 September 2026**).

The steps below are kept as written so the remaining ones can be followed, and so the reasoning is on record. Where a step is already complete it is marked.

Before anything else: Netlify has no “edit”

This is the single most dangerous thing in this document, and it already caused one outage. The Netlify DNS panel has **no edit function**. Netlify's own documentation says records cannot be edited — you add a new record and delete the old one.

An earlier version of this plan said “find the MX record, *edit it*, change the TTL”. That is impossible on Netlify, so the natural move is to delete the record and re-create it. On **about 31 August 2026 the re-create did not complete**, the domain was left with **no MX record at all**, and mail to `white-box.co.il` silently stopped being delivered for roughly a week before it was noticed. Senders queue for 3–5 days and then bounce, so some mail was lost.

The rule, and note the two halves point in opposite directions:

- **MX — add the new record FIRST, then delete the old.** Two MX records coexist harmlessly; the lower priority number simply wins. There is never a moment with no MX.
- **SPF — delete the old record FIRST, then add the new.** The opposite, because two TXT records starting `v=spf1` is a hard failure, worse than having none. A brief moment with no SPF is far safer than a moment with two.

Start here: the reassuring part

Your website will not change at all. Not one line. Your domain stays `white-box.co.il`, your email addresses stay exactly the same, and the 7 places `info@white-box.co.il` appears in the site's code stay exactly as they are. This migration changes only *where your mail is delivered*.

Your contact form does not send through the cPanel mail server, so nothing below can break the form itself. The form posts to a service called Web3Forms, and as of 1 September 2026 its only configured recipient is

`daphna.rhone@gmail.com` — not `info@` or `daphna@`. So form notifications do not follow your MX record at all, and are completely unaffected by this migration. Step 7 still has you submit the form once, but treat it as a general health check rather than a test of the mail cutover.

If you later add `info@` or `daphna@` as Web3Forms recipients, do it *after* this migration is finished and those mailboxes are confirmed receiving. Web3Forms suppresses an address that bounces and then silently stops delivering to it, so adding an address mid-cutover can quietly break notifications to it for good.

⚠ WHY THIS MIGRATION MATTERS MORE THAN IT LOOKS

A reverse lookup of the mail server `148.251.82.238` returns `cp57.box.co.il`. Your mail host is **BOX** — the provider you already left because it was terrible. The websites moved; the email never followed, and has been sitting there ever since. That is the most likely reason it "fails or disconnects often." This is not a new decision — it is finishing one you already made.

THE ONE RULE

The order of the ten steps *is* the safety mechanism. Your old mail gets copied across **while email is still flowing normally to cPanel**. By the time you flip the switch, nothing is at risk — and everything stays reversible until the very last step.

The five words you need to understand

TERM	WHAT IT ACTUALLY MEANS
DNS	The phone book of the internet. It translates <code>white-box.co.il</code> into the address of an actual computer. Yours is managed at Netlify .
MX record	The line in the phone book that says “ <i>send this domain's email to this server.</i> ” This is the switch you are flipping.
SPF	A public note saying “ <i>only these servers may send email as me.</i> ” Stops others forging your address, and keeps your mail out of spam folders.
DKIM	An invisible signature on every email you send, proving it really came from you and was not tampered with.
DMARC	Your instruction to other mail servers about what to do when an email <i>fails</i> the SPF and DKIM checks.
TTL	“Time To Live” — how long the world may remember an old answer before asking again. Lower means your changes take effect faster.

Where you will be clicking

Two websites, and it is worth being clear which is which, because it is easy to get lost:

- **Netlify** — `app.netlify.com` → **Domains** → `white-box.co.il` → **DNS records**. Every DNS change below happens here. Your DNS lives at Netlify even though your email does not.

- **Google Admin** — `admin.google.com` . Where you create mailboxes and get your DKIM key.

You will never log into cPanel again, except to check old mail and — at the very end — to cancel it.

Your DNS records: before and after

This table is the whole migration. Everything else in this document is just how to get there safely.

RECORD	BEFORE (BOX)	NOW — LIVE SINCE 7 SEP 2026
MX	<code>mail.white-box.co.il</code> priority <code>0</code>	<code>smtp.google.com</code> priority <code>1</code> ✓ done
SPF (a TXT record)	<code>v=spf1 +a +mx +ip4:148.251.82.238 ~all</code>	<code>v=spf1 include:_spf.google.com ip4:148.251.82.238 ~all</code> ✓ done simplifies to <code>v=spf1 include:_spf.google.com ~all</code> at Step 10
DKIM (TXT, <code>google._domainkey</code>)	<i>never existed</i>	a long key Google gives you — still to do
DMARC (TXT, <code>_dmarc</code>)	<i>never existed</i>	<code>v=DMARC1; p=none; rua=mailto:daphna@white-box.co.il</code> — still to do
Google verification (a TXT record)	<i>n/a</i>	<code>google-site-verification=Npp...</code> never delete this — the domain un-verifies

The `148.251.82.238` in your current SPF is the BOX server (`cp57.box.co.il`) that cPanel runs on. That is the thing you are leaving behind.

The order of operations

Read this list before doing anything.

- 1 Lower the TTL — a day ahead, so the switch happens fast
- 2 Sign up for Google Workspace and verify you own the domain
- 3 Create your mailboxes
- 4 **Copy all your old mail across** — while email still flows to cPanel
- 5 Flip the MX record — *this is the actual switch*
- 6 Fix the SPF record
- 7 Test thoroughly
- 8 Run the mail copy one final time, to catch the gap
- 9 Add DKIM and DMARC
- 10 Wait two weeks, then cancel cPanel

1 Lower the TTL — do this the day before

Why: TTL is how long the internet caches the old answer. Yours is probably 1 hour. Lower it to 5 minutes *first*, and tomorrow's switch takes effect in 5 minutes instead of an hour. A small step that removes a lot of anxiety later.

1. Netlify → Domains → `white-box.co.il` → DNS records
2. **Add a new record** that is identical to the existing MX — type `MX`, name empty, value `mail.white-box.co.il`, priority `0` — but with **TTL** `300`
3. **Then** delete the old MX record, the one whose TTL is 3600
4. **Change nothing else.**

Do not simply delete the MX and re-create it. There is no edit button (see the warning at the top of this document), and deleting first is exactly what left the domain with no MX at all and broke incoming mail for a week. Add first, delete second, so the domain is never without an MX record.

Netlify may then show the MX row **twice** even though DNS serves only one record — identical records collapse into one. That is a display quirk, not a duplicate. Do not “tidy it up” by deleting one, because there may be only one real record behind the two rows. But **do** remember both rows exist when you come to Step 5, or you will delete one and quietly leave mail pointing at BOX.

Then wait a day before Step 5. You can do Steps 2–4 during that wait.

2 Sign up and verify the domain

Go to `workspace.google.com` and sign up for **Business Starter**.

- When it asks for your domain, enter `white-box.co.il`
- Make your first account `daphna@white-box.co.il` — see Step 3 for why

Google then asks you to prove you own the domain, usually by adding a TXT record.

POSSIBLE SHORTCUT

Your site already carries a Google Search Console verification tag. Google sometimes recognises this and skips verification entirely. If it offers, take it.

If you do need to add the record:

1. Netlify → DNS records → **Add new record**
2. **Type:** TXT
3. **Name:** leave empty. Netlify may show this as `@` or as the bare domain — all three mean “the domain itself”
4. **Value:** paste exactly what Google gives you (it starts with `google-site-verification=`)
5. Save, then click verify in Google. Usually works within minutes.

⚠ DO NOT TIDY UP

You now have **two** TXT records on the domain — your existing SPF, and this new verification one. **That is correct and expected.** Do not delete the SPF one to “make room.” Multiple TXT records are completely normal.

3 Create your mailboxes — and save money

You have two addresses, but you probably only need **one paid account**.

- `daphna@white-box.co.il` — your real user account. This is the one you pay for.
- `info@white-box.co.il` — add as an **alias** on that same account.

An alias is free. Mail to `info@` lands in the same inbox, and you can still *send* as `info@` when you want to appear as the studio rather than yourself. That is roughly **27 ILS per month instead of 54**.

To set it up: Admin → Directory → Users → click the user's *name* → on the left-hand card, **ADD ALTERNATE EMAILS** → type `info` (just that, not the full address) → **SAVE**.

On this domain the alias is not optional. On BOX, `info@` was a **forwarder** to `daphna@`, not a mailbox. That forwarder stops working the moment the MX leaves BOX, and the alias is its only replacement. If the MX is switched before the alias exists, every message to `info@` bounces — and `info@` is the address printed in seven places on the website.

Three things that waste time here:

- The Users list shows **one user** and that is correct. Aliases are not accounts and never appear as rows. If `info@` *did* appear as a second user, it would be a second paid seat and should be removed.
- The Users **search box does not match aliases**. Searching `info@white-box.co.il` finds nothing even when the alias exists. Use “**Show all alternate emails**” on the user's page — that is the reliable check.
- A **greyed-out SAVE button means the alias is already saved**, not that saving failed. These forms only enable SAVE when something has changed.

Only make `info@` a separate paid account if someone *other than you* needs their own private login for it.

4 Copy your old mail across — the important one

Do this while email is still being delivered to cPanel. You are copying, not moving. Nothing is deleted from cPanel, so there is no way to lose anything at this step.

Google Admin → **Data** → **Data import & export** → **Data Import**. The page is headed “*Import data from IMAP*”.

The name has changed. Google's old “Data migration” label is gone, and searching the admin console for “data migration” finds nothing useful. It is now **Data Import**, under **Data → Data import & export** in the left-hand menu. The direct URL `admin.google.com/ac/dm` does *not* reach it — it lands on an unrelated page.

The first screen asks only for the IMAP server address. Enter `mail.white-box.co.il` on its own — no `https://`, no port — and press **Test connection**. It then asks for the mailbox credentials.

SETTING	VALUE
Migration source	Other IMAP server (may appear as “IMAP” or “Generic IMAP”)
Server	<code>mail.white-box.co.il</code>
Port	<code>993</code> , with SSL enabled
Username / password	your existing cPanel mailbox credentials

Run it for both `info@` and `daphna@` if they are separate mailboxes on cPanel today.

Depending on how many years of mail you have, this takes anywhere from minutes to several hours. Let it finish. Then **open Gmail and actually look** — confirm old messages are really there and folders came across — before going anywhere near Step 5.

Port 993 was verified as open and reachable on your mail server, so this connection should work.

5 Flip the MX record — the actual switch

This is the moment new mail starts going to Google. With TTL at 300, it takes about 5 minutes.

Add first, delete second. While both records exist, BOX is priority `0` and Google is priority `1`; the lower number wins, so mail keeps going to BOX and nothing has changed yet. Only deleting the BOX records performs the switch.

1. Netlify → DNS records → **Add new record**, with the values below
2. Check it is live before going further
3. **Then delete every** `mail.white-box.co.il` MX record — there may be **two rows**, and both must go
4. Confirm the only MX left is `smtp.google.com`

Type: MX
Name: (leave empty – the domain itself)
Value: `smtp.google.com`
Priority: 1
TTL: 300

Delete both rows. Netlify listed `mail.white-box.co.il` twice during the real cutover. Deleting only one leaves mail routed to BOX while everything looks finished — the failure would be silent.

Verify from outside afterwards rather than trusting the panel: `nslookup -type=MX white-box.co.il 8.8.8.8` should return **one** record, `smtp.google.com`.

That single record is all Google needs — they simplified this in 2023. If you find an older guide listing five `ASPMX.L.GOOGLE.COM` records, that is the legacy setup. It still works, but you do not need it.

TIMING

Do this on a **weekday morning**, not a Friday afternoon — so if anything looks wrong, you have the whole day to sort it out.

6 Fix the SPF record

Do this straight after the MX change. If you skip it, mail you send from Gmail may land in recipients' spam folders.

Delete first, add second — the opposite order to Step 5. Two TXT records starting `v=spf1` is a hard failure, worse than having none at all, so a brief moment with no SPF is much safer than a moment with two.

1. Netlify → DNS records → find the TXT record whose value starts with `v=spf1`
2. **Delete it.** There is no edit button — see the warning at the top
3. **Immediately add a new record:** type `TXT`, name empty, TTL `300`, value:

```
v=spf1 include:_spf.google.com ip4:148.251.82.238 ~all
```

Do not touch the other TXT record — the one reading `google-site-verification=...`. Google re-checks it periodically and will un-verify the domain if it disappears. When you are done you should have **exactly two** TXT records: this SPF, and that verification string.

Check from outside: `nslookup -type=TXT white-box.co.il 8.8.8.8` — exactly one line should begin `v=spf1`.

This temporarily authorises **both** Google and your old server, which is the safe choice while both still exist.

Later, once cPanel is cancelled in Step 10, simplify it to:

```
v=spf1 include:_spf.google.com ~all
```

7 Test

Do not skip this, and do not test in only one direction.

- ☐ Send an email **from** Gmail **to** your personal Gmail or other address — it arrives, and is **not** in spam
- ☐ Send an email **from** that outside address **to** `info@white-box.co.il` — it arrives in Gmail
- ☐ Repeat the incoming test for `daphna@white-box.co.il`
- ☐ Submit the contact form on `white-box.co.il` and confirm the notification reaches `daphna.rhone@gmail.com` (a general health check, not a test of the mail cutover — the form does not use your MX record)
- ☐ Reply to a message and confirm the reply sends

You can check the DNS side at `mxtoolbox.com` — enter `white-box.co.il`, and MX should show `smtp.google.com`.

Test before you switch, not only after. Google gives every Workspace domain a free mirror at `<yourdomain>.test-google-a.com`, which points at Google's mail servers regardless of your own MX. So you can prove the mailbox and the alias work *while mail is still going to BOX*. Send from any outside address to:

`daphna@white-box.co.il.test-google-a.com`
`info@white-box.co.il.test-google-a.com`

Both should arrive in the new inbox — **check the Spam folder**, because a brand-new mailbox with no history is cautious and the first test almost certainly lands there. This removes nearly all the risk from Step 5: by the time you change the MX you already know the destination receives.

8 Run the migration once more

Between your Step 4 copy and the Step 5 switch, a few emails may have landed on cPanel. Re-run the same Data Migration from Step 4. It skips everything already copied and picks up only the stragglers.

9 Add DKIM and DMARC

These are not strictly required for mail to work, but they are what keeps you out of spam folders long term. Do them a few days after everything else is stable.

DKIM

1. Google Admin → **Apps** → **Google Workspace** → **Gmail** → **Authenticate email**
2. Click **Generate new record** — use 2048-bit
3. Google shows you a **name** (`google._domainkey`) and a very long **value**
4. In Netlify: Add new record → Type **TXT** → Name `google._domainkey` → Value: the long string, pasted exactly
5. Wait about 15 minutes, return to Google, click **Start authentication**

Copy that long value carefully. A single missing character breaks it silently.

DMARC

Add one more TXT record in Netlify:

Name: `_dmarc`
Value: `v=DMARC1; p=none; rua=mailto:daphna@white-box.co.il`

`p=none` means “**monitor only, block nothing.**” This is deliberate: you get reports with zero risk of legitimate mail being rejected. Only consider tightening to `p=quarantine` after months of clean reports, and there is no urgency at all.

⚠ NEVER DO THIS

Do not start with `p=reject`. It can silently destroy real email.

10 Cancel cPanel

Wait a full two weeks after Step 7 passes. Not two days. You want certainty that nothing was missed — including monthly senders such as invoices, or suppliers who email you only occasionally.

Once you are confident:

1. Do one last check of the cPanel webmail for anything unexpected
2. Simplify SPF to `v=spf1 include:_spf.google.com ~all` — drop the old server's IP
3. Raise TTLs back to `3600`. You no longer need fast changes
4. Cancel the cPanel account

THE BONUS

Those “AutoSSL reduced coverage” warning emails stop **forever**. That whole problem existed only because the cPanel server was trying to manage certificates for a website it does not host. Once mail leaves, the account has no reason to exist.

Five mistakes that break email

Worth reading twice. The first one is not hypothetical — it happened.

1. **Deleting a record in order to change it.** Netlify has no edit button, so changing a record means delete-and-recreate — and if the recreate does not complete you are left with nothing. This is what removed the MX record around 31 August 2026 and stopped incoming mail for a week. For **MX, add the new record first and delete second**. Only SPF works the other way round, and only because two SPF records is itself a failure.
2. **Two SPF records.** You must have **exactly one** TXT record starting with `v=spf1`. Two is worse than none — mail servers see the conflict and fail the check entirely.
3. **Deleting the wrong TXT record.** After Step 2 you will have several TXT records on the domain: SPF, Google verification, and later DKIM and DMARC. They coexist happily. Deleting one to tidy up breaks whatever depended on it.
4. **Switching MX before copying mail.** Flip MX first and new mail arrives in an empty Google mailbox while your history sits stranded on a server you are about to cancel. Copy first. Always.
5. **Cancelling cPanel too early.** A few more weeks of hosting fees is *nothing* compared to discovering in October that a client's email from September went to a server that no longer exists.

If something goes wrong

You can always undo the switch. Nothing here is permanent until you cancel cPanel in Step 10 — which is exactly why Step 10 is last.

To roll back: in Netlify, **add** the original MX record back first, then delete the `smtp.google.com` one. With TTL at 300, mail flows back to cPanel within about 5 minutes, exactly as before. This works only while the cPanel account still exists, which is the real reason Step 10 waits two weeks.

ROLLBACK MX RECORD — KEEP THIS WHERE YOU CAN FIND IT

`mail.white-box.co.il` `priority 0`

Quick reference card

Keep this page beside you while you work. It contains every value you need to type.

WHITE BOX STUDIO — DNS

FINAL STATE, AT NETLIFY

MX	(name empty)	smtp.google.com	priority 1
TXT	(name empty)	v=spf1 include:_spf.google.com ~all	
TXT	google._domainkey	v=DKIM1; k=rsa; p=... (from Google)	
TXT	_dmarc	v=DMARC1; p=none; rua=mailto:daphna@white-box.co.il	

DURING THE OVERLAP (STEP 6, TEMPORARY)

TXT	(name empty)	v=spf1 include:_spf.google.com ip4:148.251.82.238 ~all	
-----	--------------	---	--

ROLLBACK, IF NEEDED

MX	(name empty)	mail.white-box.co.il	priority 0
----	--------------	----------------------	------------

OLD SERVER — WHAT YOU ARE LEAVING BEHIND

Hetzner / cPanel	148.251.82.238
IMAP, for the migration	mail.white-box.co.il : 993 (SSL)

WHERE TO CLICK

DNS changes	app.netlify.com Domains > white-box.co.il > DNS records
Mailboxes, DKIM	admin.google.com
Check your work	mxtoolbox.com

IF ANYTHING GOES WRONG, THIS ONE RECORD UNDOES EVERYTHING

MX mail.white-box.co.il priority 0

DNS values in this document were read from the live white-box.co.il zone on 11 August 2026, and every one of them was re-verified against live DNS during the real cutover on **7 September 2026**, when Steps 1–7 were carried out and external mail was confirmed arriving in Gmail. Google's single-MX recommendation (`smtp.google.com`, priority 1) was confirmed against Google's current documentation. Steps 8–10 remain outstanding: re-run the mail import, add DKIM and DMARC, and do not cancel BOX before about 21 September 2026.